

DEBATEWATCH 2000: REFLECTIONS OF A MODERATOR

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The presidential campaign of 2000 provided countless demonstrations of rhetorical and oratorical strategy. The eventual showdown between the two-term Vice President and the Governor of Texas obviously will be remembered for the amazing down-to-the-wire race and the turmoil in Florida. The campaign of 2000 should also be remembered and revisited because of the personal and political insights made possible by DebateWatch 2000. In what follows, I will attempt to offer some insights into the benefits of the DebateWatch program and some reflections unique to DebateWatch 2000. Rather than making a contribution to argumentation theory, my aim is to provide a context for understanding past and future DebateWatch events, given that readers of this journal are likely to be invited to contribute to these events in the future.

DebateWatch was introduced in 1996 by the Commission on Presidential Debates (CPD). The CPD was created in 1987 and has sponsored and produced all presidential and vice presidential debates since 1988 (Commission, 2001). While the CPD and DebateWatch are most noted for organizing presidential and vice-presidential debates, the guidelines and suggestions offered by CPD can be used for various levels of elections. A detailed guide for sponsoring and participating in a DebateWatch debate, including some basic argumentation and debate considerations, is available on the CPD website (Commission, 2001).¹

I had the opportunity to participate in a DebateWatch 2000 event held at Wayland Baptist University and coordinated by Professor Virginia Myers. Wayland Baptist, which is located in Plainview, Texas, was one of over 140 colleges and universities across the country to host a debate watch. My role was to moderate the pre- and post-debate discussion among panelists and attendees. We were gathered on October 17, 2000, to observe the third and final presidential debate. A few of the organizational elements of the Wayland DebateWatch are worth noting.

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¹ National Communication Association members were instrumental in putting together the DebateWatch guide. Those members include Diana Carlin, Robert Friedenberg, James Gaudino, Susan Hellweg, John Morello, and Michael Pfau.

Professor Myers incorporated the DebateWatch program into her small group communication course. Much of the preparation and facilitation of the event was handled by these students as a major project in the course. This provided an excellent learning opportunity for the students who were able to practice group and organizational skills as well as observe the presidential debate as part of their class. The event also allowed these students to provide a community service to the citizens of Plainview who were able to attend the debate and participate in the discussions.

The organizing committee invited approximately 12 individuals to participate on the panel. The organizers sought out participants who claimed to be undecided voters going into the third and final presidential debate. The participants included local high school students, Wayland students, and a Wayland faculty member. Spokespersons from the local Republican and Democratic Parties were also present to participate in the debate.

The event was structured such that people arrived early enough to enjoy light refreshments, get situated at a table, and be introduced to the panel participants. As moderator, I also asked participants to fill out a pre-debate and post-debate continuum which recorded their presidential preferences. The scale was a simple 11 point continuum which ranged from five to zero and back to five. The fives were strongly favor Bush or Gore and the ones were slightly favor Bush or Gore. Zero was to indicate an absolutely undecided voter.

Before Debate

Bush 5-----4-----3-----2-----1-----0-----1-----2-----3-----4-----5 Gore

After Debate

Bush 5-----4-----3-----2-----1-----0-----1-----2-----3-----4-----5 Gore

Immediately prior to the beginning of the debate, audience members were invited to create their own continua and participate in the voting process with the panelists. With the preliminaries completed, moderator Jim Lehrer greeted the television audience (The 2000 Campaign, 2001), and all eyes were focused on the televised debate.

In Plainview, panelists and audience members alike reacted aloud at various times during the debate, and some chose to jot brief notes on what they heard. Panelists were

encouraged to take notes of influential moments in the debate. Questions were prepared in advance for the panelists to respond to after the debate.

There were some very unique elements in the Wayland Baptist DebateWatch that provide insights into the whole DebateWatch program. Initially, there were some on the panel who would seem to agree with Professor James Andrews (2000), who noted during the 2000 presidential campaign “It is distressing how little we actually discuss real issues.” While the sentiment was not shared by all, some of the panelists claimed that one or both candidates gave superficial, pre-prepared responses to questions that took away from the debate that was supposed to take place. However, the full range of panelists and attendees regarded the DebateWatch experience as a worthwhile and enjoyable one.

The closeness of the presidential race certainly placed additional emphasis on the 2000 debates and the role to be played by the undecided voter. A reporter for the *Houston Chronicle* reported that “This year’s debates seem to have played an unusual role in the campaign. Rather than being decisive (as in nailing down the victory for the elder George Bush in 1988 and Bill Clinton in 1992 and 1996), these three face-offs have been more equivocal” (Hines, 2000, p. 42). With three weeks remaining after the final debate, the race was a virtual tie. A *USA Today/CNN/Gallup* tracking poll showed Bush leading 47 percent to 44 percent, but with the three percentage points being within the poll’s margin of error (Robison & Bernstein, 2000). The *San Francisco Examiner* (Salladay, 2000) reported that between five and ten percent of voters were undecided and possibly 20 percent could change their vote before election day. The tight presidential race made DebateWatch participants who were undecided voters a valuable commodity. However, there would seem to be reason to speculate on how undecided the undecided voters really were. R.W. Apple, Jr. (2000) of the *New York Times* wrote that “the final presidential debate of 2000 was more about reinforcing political views previously reached than about arriving at new conclusions” (p. A1). He also reported that most of the observers who watched the debate at a location near the University of Michigan reported that their voting preferences were unchanged after the debate.

Responses from the Wayland panelists suggested they were not truly undecided, but rather were looking for confirmation that they were leaning in the correct direction. When asked to complete the pre-debate self-evaluation on which way they were leaning, none of the panel participants marked themselves as “0,” meaning truly undecided. In fact the average was between a two and a three in favor of one candidate or the other. More of the

Wayland participants were initially predisposed toward George Bush, which was not surprising given the location in West Texas. While there was much speculation in the media about the number of undecided voters going into the third debate, my suspicion is that the number of *truly* undecided voters was smaller than many thought. The number was certainly very small in the Wayland DebateWatch.

Comments from Wayland panelists following the debate revealed that individuals recounted positions taken in the debate by their preferred candidates. The panelists knew which positions they were ultimately voting on (e.g., the Wayland audience was particularly interested in arguments concerning prescription drugs, the various education topics, and agricultural policy) and which candidate best represented their view on those issues. Their arguments following the debate were largely restatements of positions they knew before the debate. Yet, many panelists seemed to take solace in hearing their positions addressed once more by their candidate.

There was a tendency for these panelists to filter through the content during the debate until they heard issues of particular importance to them. Many of the older members of the audience were particularly interested in the early question which focused on Health Maintenance Organizations and insurance, while the younger students were drawn to the education questions. It appears that the role of DebateWatch is best fulfilled when members of the viewing audience are able to explain to each other why a particular issue was important to them. For example, closing comments for the evening were provided by representatives from the local Republican and Democratic Parties. Both individuals paid particular attention to the issue of health care. Each representative was able to elaborate on the position advocated during the previous debate. However, the representatives in the room were better able to reach the full range of audience members while delivering virtually the same message as their respective presidential candidate. It appears that, on occasion, the presidential debate serves the function of presenting the issue of dispute. Then, the more effective advocacy at the DebateWatch events comes from the panelists and individuals who attend the debate.

It was apparent that this particular audience was very attentive to the non-verbal elements of the debate. I suspect this is a common occurrence with DebateWatch gatherings. At Wayland, this might have been facilitated by the fact that the debate was being viewed on a large projection screen. It is also the case that reactions to comments on individual issues are limited, as not everyone in the audience has the same priorities and

concerns. However, most viewing members attend to and assign meaning to the candidates' non-verbal cues. Therefore, larger reactions were seen from some of the non-verbal elements of the debate. Most notably, the viewers reacted to the early strategy of Vice President Gore to physically approach Governor Bush while the Governor was finishing an answer. It would be interesting to assess whether there is a persuasive effect on audience members who witness other members' reaction to non-verbal cues. Judging from post-debate discussion at Wayland, that would seem to be a possibility and a unique result of groups of people observing a presidential debate in a format such as the one offered by DebateWatch.

As for winners and losers in the third presidential debate, the Wayland panelists differed from many other analysts by claiming that George Bush was the victor. Many observers considered the debate to be somewhere between a tie and a slight Gore victory. An editorial in the *Austin American-Statesman*, for example, noted that, although Gore was given the advantage by the pundits, the debate shed little light to guide the undecided. "There was a rhetorical exchange about patients bill of rights legislation that only a wonk could love, and both candidates didn't hesitate to dance the sidestep" (Presidential debates, 2000, p. A16). Craig Hines's commentary was also representative of many reports as he concluded that "I scored the final round as a marginal Gore victory, but so narrow as possibly to be without meaning to the overall race" (Hines, 2000, p. 42). The Wayland panelists, however, voted a majority victory for George Bush. However, the majority were initially leaning toward Bush before the debate. The panelists' responses following the debate indicated that they were more committed to the candidate they preferred before the debate.

Finally, the role of moderator deserves special attention, as scholars with expertise in communication studies, and particularly in argumentation, are likely to be invited to perform this task. The role of the moderator in DebateWatch events is important because the moderator will likely be the person responsible for initiating and facilitating discussion before and after the debate. The CPD provides sample questions on their website, which moderators can use to help generate useful discussion following these debates. At Wayland Baptist I was afforded the opportunity to generate my own questions, which were tailored specifically for the West Texas community. It is helpful if the moderator is comfortable creating questions and responding to comments in such a way as to invite continued, focused discussion. In essence, a moderator who can employ a sustained and critical

dialectic with the panelists and auditors will be more likely to create a positive and educational experience for all the discussants.

In this case, the moderator also was selected to create a less partisan atmosphere for assessing the presidential debate. The event organizer made the decision to use someone from outside the immediate community as moderator in the Wayland Baptist event. While I drove only 30 minutes to reach the event site in Plainview, my impression is that the audience preferred a moderator who was largely unknown to the panelists and audience, which added to the sense of the debate being organized in a non-partisan manner. A moderator whose political preferences are unknown and who appears to facilitate a balanced discussion will make accusations of partisanship more difficult to sustain.

DebateWatch provides a wonderful opportunity for communication studies faculty and students to learn about the campaign, the debate process, and disparate public responses to the debates while engaging in a form of service learning. However, this experience need not be limited to every fourth year. The DebateWatch format and guidelines can be used to bring public attention to state, regional, local or campus debates (see Commission, 2001). From the Wayland experience, I learned that participation in DebateWatch allows students and faculty to share in the wonderful feeling of combining learning, public service, and participation in one of the most sacred rights and responsibilities of American citizenship.

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